

Gossip: The Social Glue [B1]

Il pettegolezzo non è certo un'abitudine dei giorni nostri: ce lo dimostra l'origine della parola 'gossip'.



Sometimes, [over time](#), a word loses its original positive meaning and gradually takes on a negative one. How does this happen? A good example is the word

‘gossip’, which today often has a negative connotation. ‘Gossip’ comes from ‘godsibb’, an Old English term made up of ‘god’ and ‘sibb’ meaning ‘relationship’ or ‘affinity’. It referred to a relative connected, not by blood, but spiritually through God. In the Middle Ages, godsibs were the [godfathers and godmothers](#) present at a baptism. Their role was to support the biological family and they represented close friendship, [trust](#) and care. At the time, these relationships were strong [bonds](#), socially significant and in some cases even [legally binding](#).

WOMEN’S SPEECH

In the late Middle Ages and during the Renaissance, the term began to refer to [trusted](#) female members of the community who assisted women during childbirth. They were close friends of the family and spent [a great deal](#) of time with them, talking freely about everything and sharing news, stories, and secrets. Between the 14th and 15th centuries, the word ‘godsibb’ was shortened to ‘gossip’, and its meaning gradually [shifted](#) from referring to a person to describing a type of behaviour; that is, instead of a [trusted](#) intimate person, it referred to informal conversation [engaged in](#) by a [talkative](#) companion.

USELESS TALK

Between the 16th and 17th centuries, ‘gossip’ began to acquire a [derogatory](#) meaning and became associated with women’s domestic talk and engagement in conversations considered [pointless](#) or trivial. Women’s words were increasingly devalued, especially in contrast to male-dominated written and institutional discourse. The opposition between oral and written communication became [sharper](#) and reflected the [widening gap](#) between private and public spheres. Language

Small Talk is Great Alla macchinetta del caffè o con il passeggero che ci è seduto accanto in aereo: una chiacchiera, seppur superficiale, aiuta a creare un’intesa.
Daniel Francis

GENDERED

For centuries, gossip was closely connected to gender and was often [dismissed](#). Its shift from a word about [trust](#) and care to one about socially [reprehensible behaviour](#) isn’t just a linguistic change, but also reflects a broader social and cultural transformation. Women and the lower social classes were associated with ‘inferior’ oral, informal and non-institutional language. Such attitudes stigmatised and delegitimised certain groups, reflecting imbalances of power.

SOCIAL GLUE

Today, linguistics and sociology often re-evaluate gossip as social [glue](#) through which relational [bonds](#) are formed, moral values are shared and group identity reinforced. This function is often compared to social [grooming](#) in primates.

GOSSIP, RUMOUR OR HEARSAY?

Gossip usually focuses on people, their behaviours and relationships. The word ‘rumour’, instead, refers primarily to events or facts whose truth is uncertain. ‘[Hearsay](#)’ is a more formal term, mainly used in legal contexts. It describes information learned through others, without direct evidence, and is often not accepted as evidence in a [court of law](#).

GOSSIP IN LITERATURE

Gossip plays an important role in literature, where it often becomes a narrative engine. In William Shakespeare, the word ‘gossip’ still means ‘godmother’ or ‘close female friend’, but it already suggests the idea of indiscreet talk. This shows a moment of transition in meaning. Shakespeare uses gossip in a [strikingly](#) modern way: the plot in Othello or [Much Ado About Nothing](#), for example, develops around the circulation of gossip that anticipates what we would now call disinformation or an early form of fake news, with the [aim](#) of insinuating, suggesting and manipulating. Jane Austen is also a master in the use of gossip to [move the plot](#). In novels such as Pride and Prejudice or Emma, the gossip circulating in small, closed social circles [shapes](#) reputations and strongly influences marriages or social exclusion. In Oscar Wilde, on the other hand, moral judgment is reversed: gossip is presented as entertainment and social performance, exposing the hypocrisy of Victorian society. Silence means invisibility, and visibility means power. This theme is [embodied](#) in his novel The Picture of Dorian Gray, where the character Lord Henry Wotton [asserts](#): “The only thing worse than being talked about is not being talked about.”

Glossary

- **glue** = collante
- **strikingly** = sorprendentemente
- **Much Ado About Nothing** = “Molto rumore per nulla”
- **move the plot** = far avanzare la trama
- **trust** = fiducia
- **shifted** = cambiare
- **dismissed** = sminuire
- **grooming** = toelettatura, pulizia sociale (etologia)
- **Hearsay** = voci di corridoio, testimonianza per sentito dire
- **court of law** = tribunale
- **shapes** = modellare
- **asserts** = affermare, sostenere
- **legally binding** = legalmente vincolante
- **engaged in** = partecipare a
- **talkative** = loquace, chiacchierone
- **widening gap** = divario crescente
- **reprehensible behaviour** = comportamento riprovevole
- **embodied** = incarnare, personificare
- **godfathers and godmothers** = padrini e madrine
- **bonds** = legami
- **a great deal** = una grande quantità
- **derogatory** = peggiorativo, dispregiativo
- **sharper** = più marcato
- **aim** = obiettivo
- **over time** = col passare del tempo
- **pointless** = futile